

IMAP & Reply Handling

Brevo Email Pipeline — what `IMAP_*` does, and exactly what breaks without it

First: there is no auto-reply.

This system **never sends an automatic response** to someone who replies. No auto-responder exists anywhere in the code.

What reply detection actually does is **stop the follow-up sequence**. That is the entire point. Answering a prospect is a human job.

What IMAP is

Brevo sends mail **out**. IMAP is the only way this app sees anything coming **back**. Two different systems, two different directions.

`worker/reply-scan.mjs` logs into the reply mailbox every `REPLY_INTERVAL_MINUTES` (default 5), reads unread messages, and for each one:

```
parse → match sender to a contact → classify with AI → SAVE to email_replies → act
```

The "act" step is: stop the sequence, suppress the address, or (for out-of-office) defer the next step by `000_DEFER_DAYS`.

It is env-gated. `replyScanEnabled()` requires **all three** of `IMAP_HOST`, `IMAP_USER`, `IMAP_PASS`. Miss one and the whole scanner is dormant — the worker just logs `DISABLED` and carries on sending.

With vs without

	IMAP configured	IMAP missing (today)
Reply reaches your mailbox	Yes	Yes (delivery is unrelated)
App can see the reply	Yes	Never
Saved to <code>email_replies</code>	Yes	Not saved at all
Follow-up stops on reply	Yes	Keeps sending
Address added to suppressions	Yes	No
Out-of-office defers instead of stopping	Yes	No
"Unsubscribe" reply honoured	Yes	No
Auto-reply sent to the customer	Never	Never

The reply still **arrives** in the mailbox either way. A human can read it. The *application* simply never learns it happened.

The consequences, in order of severity

1. You keep emailing people who already answered

A prospect replies Monday; your 48-hour follow-up goes out Wednesday asking whether they saw your last email. Nothing signals "automated blast" more clearly.

2. Unsubscribe requests are silently ignored

Because `APP_BASE_URL` is unset, `src/lib/unsubscribe.js` falls back to a footer reading "reply with 'unsubscribe'". **A reply is currently the only unsubscribe channel offered — and nobody is reading it.** Someone can ask to be removed and keep receiving mail. That is a compliance problem, not just an embarrassment.

3. Interested leads are lost

The most valuable reply you can get is indistinguishable from silence, because nothing records it.

Why this is the easy gap to close

IMAP is **outbound** — the worker dials out to the mail server and pulls. No public URL, no tunnel, no deployment. It works from a laptop.

That is the opposite of the Brevo webhook (bounce/complaint handling), which needs the internet to reach *you*. Of the two gaps, IMAP is the one that can be closed today, for free.

Current status

`.env` has the block, with `IMAP_PASS` filled in — but One.com rejects it:

```
responseText:      Authentication failed.
serverResponseCode: AUTHENTICATIONFAILED
```

Ruled out: the password parses cleanly from `.env` (correct length, no stray quotes or whitespace), TLS connects, and `imap.one.com:993` returns a valid Dovecot greeting. The credential itself is being refused.

Most likely cause: `outreach@radiusai.online` is an **alias, not a mailbox**. An alias forwards mail and has no inbox to log into, which the server reports as an auth failure.

To find out, email `outreach@radiusai.online` from a personal address:

- **Arrives somewhere** → it's an alias. Point `IMAP_*` at that destination mailbox instead.
- **Bounces** → no mailbox and no forward, so `BREVO_REPLY_TO` points nowhere and every reply so far has vanished. Fix this before anything else.
- **Opens in One.com webmail** at that address → real mailbox, password is wrong.

Then run `npm run imap:test` (read-only; never marks mail as read).

Don't retry the password repeatedly. One.com appears to throttle after failed logins, and you can get temporarily blocked.

Gotcha once it works

`reply-scan.mjs` searches for **unseen** messages only, then marks them seen. **If you open a reply in your mail app before the worker polls it, the worker never processes it** — no stop, no save, follow-up goes out anyway.

Use a mailbox you don't read manually, or leave it alone during working hours.

Related

- `email_replies` table — `schema.sql` (gitignored; run `npm run db:setup`)
- Scanner — `worker/reply-scan.mjs`
- Classifier — `src/lib/classify.js` (needs `OPENAI_API_KEY` or `ANTHROPIC_API_KEY` ; without either it degrades to "any reply → stop")
- Connection test — `npm run imap:test`